

Rao further wrote that the thermal efficiency of a steam locomotive was 7–12 per cent while diesel was at 28–32 per cent and electric at 50 per cent. High operating and maintenance costs sealed the fate of steam locomotives. By 1970–80, Rao wrote, diesel and electric did not make up even half of the total locomotives in use, and yet hauled “88.6 per cent of the total gross tonne kilometres of goods against only 11.4 per cent hauled by steam locomotives”. He added that the “engine kilometres per day per engine on line were three to four times those of steam locomotives and the speeds nearly double, on the broad gauge”.

By the late 1990s, steam had practically gone out of circulation. “The age of steam engines is ending in India,” lamented a 1993 article in the British newspaper *Independent*. “By 1996, all of India’s remaining steam trains will be replaced by diesel ones, which cost less to maintain and are faster and more muscular”. Another enthusiast wrote, in a 1994 letter to the Indian newspaper *Times of India*, “Please keep some steam for me when I come next year”. In April 1997, a mere 75 steam locomotives were running across the country. Today, there is a small fraction of that number. Most run in the hill railway system or have become a part of the railway heritage.

Remembering the black beauty

The steam locomotive, railway enthusiast Joydeep Dutta wrote in an essay for the Indian Steam Railway Society’s annual magazine, “was the most human machine ever designed. It has a personality of its own”. It is perhaps why steam locomotives have managed to stay on in public memory.

Despite the fact that many engines were later sold as scrap, others made their way to museums as an important part of railway heritage. The *Antim Sitara* today finds pride of place at the CLW locomotive park as does the *Deshbandhu*, India’s first indigenously produced steam engine. The Rewari Railway Heritage Museum in Haryana and the National Rail Museum in New Delhi have preserved several steam locomotives, including the iconic [*Fairy Queen*](#).

Heritage runs are made across the country regularly, such as in 2010 when the [EIR 21](#), hauled one coach between Chennai Egmore and